

INBOX ZERO, MEETINGS HANDLED

Turn AI Into Your Email and Meeting Machine

The eight AI workflows that hand you back the two things eating your day,
email and meetings, with no code and no new subscription.

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A companion to The Artificial Advantage · elvinpeters.com

Why this exists

Ask any professional where their day actually goes and you will hear the same two words: email and meetings. You sit down to do the work you were hired for, and the inbox is already at forty unread. By the time you clear it, three meetings have stacked up, each one generating its own follow-ups, each follow-up generating its own thread. The real job gets pushed to after hours. This is not a discipline problem. It is a volume problem, and AI is finally good enough to take most of that volume off your plate.

This guide is not about prompt theory. It is about the eight specific workflows that turn the two biggest time-sinks in your week into something you handle in minutes. Drafting a reply that actually sounds like you. Catching up on a forty-message thread without reading it. Writing the email you have been dreading, the one where you say no or deliver bad news. Walking into every meeting already briefed. Turning a messy transcript into a clean list of decisions and owners. Chasing the people who owe you things without nagging or burning the relationship.

A note on what is real. The features described here exist today, in the tools you already pay for. Gmail now summarizes long threads and drafts replies in your style for free. Outlook condenses email chains into decisions, open questions, and action items, and Teams produces a full recap with owners after any recorded meeting. ChatGPT records a meeting and turns it into structured notes. None of this requires a new subscription or a developer. It requires knowing which moves to make, and that is the whole point of what follows.

1. Draft replies in your own voice, in seconds

The reason most people will not let AI write their email is that the output reads like a press release. Stiff, over-polite, full of phrases you would never say. The fix is not a better tool. It is teaching the tool your voice once, so every draft after that sounds like you wrote it on a good day.

How to do it: Take three or four emails you have actually sent, ones you are proud of, and paste them in with a simple instruction: "This is how I write. Match this tone, length, and level of formality in everything you draft for me." If you use a tool with saved instructions, such as a Claude Project or a custom ChatGPT setup, put that note there once and it sticks across every conversation. Then for each reply, give it the incoming message and one line about your intent: agree but push the date, decline politely, ask for the missing number. The tool does the assembly, you do the approve.

Generic AI draft: "Thank you so much for reaching out regarding the proposed timeline. I wanted to take a moment to express my appreciation for your patience and to confirm that we are diligently working to accommodate your request. Please rest assured that..."

Trained on your voice: "Thanks Priya. I can make the Thursday deadline work, but I'll need the final logo files from your side by Tuesday morning to do it. Can you get those over? If not, Friday is the honest date."

The second one took the same ten seconds to generate. The difference is that you spent five minutes once, up front, showing it who you are.

2. Catch up on a brutal thread without reading it

You open a thread that has been bouncing between six people for two days and your stomach drops. Somewhere in there is a decision you are now responsible for, buried under reply-all noise, forwarded chains, and one person who writes in paragraphs. Reading the whole thing to find the one thing you need is a tax you pay several times a day.

How to do it: This is what thread summarization was built for. In Gmail, the built-in AI Overview will synthesize a long conversation into the key points for you. If you prefer to drive it yourself, copy the entire thread into your AI tool and ask a pointed question instead of a vague one. Do not say "summarize this." Say what you actually need to know.

Your prompt: "Below is a long email thread I was just added to. In plain language, tell me three things. One, what decision is being made or has been made. Two, is there anything I am specifically being asked to do, and by when. Three, is there any disagreement or open question I should be aware of before I reply. Quote the exact line for anything that involves me."

What comes back: "1. The team is deciding whether to push the launch to Q3. No final call yet. 2. You are being asked to confirm budget availability by end of day Friday. The exact line, from Marcus: 'Need Elvin to confirm we have room in the Q2 spend before we commit.' 3. Open disagreement: Dana wants to launch on time with a smaller scope, Marcus wants to delay. They have not resolved it."

The "quote the exact line for anything that involves me" instruction is the difference between a summary you trust and a summary you have to double-check. It forces the tool to point at the real text instead of paraphrasing you into a corner.

3. Write the hard email

Saying no. Chasing a payment. Telling a client the thing slipped. Pushing back on your boss without it landing wrong. These are the emails that sit in your drafts for an hour while you rewrite the opening line six times. The hard part is rarely the information. It is the tone, the balance between honest and diplomatic, firm and warm. This is exactly where AI earns its keep, because it has no ego in the conversation and can hand you three versions to react to.

How to do it: Give it the situation honestly, including the parts you would not put in the email, then tell it the relationship and the outcome you want. The off-the-record context is what makes the draft land right.

Your prompt: "I need to decline a request. A junior colleague, Tom, asked me to review and rewrite his entire forty-page report by tomorrow. I genuinely do not have time, and honestly it is not my job to rewrite it, but I do not want to crush him or seem unhelpful. Write a short, warm reply that says no to the full rewrite, offers one concrete smaller thing I can actually do, like a quick pass on the executive summary, and keeps the door open. No corporate filler."

What comes back: "Hi Tom, I won't be able to take on a full rewrite by tomorrow, that's more than I can give it the time it deserves on that timeline. What I can do is read your executive summary first thing in the morning and give you sharp feedback on that, since it's the part most people actually read. If that's useful, send it over tonight and I'll turn it around by 10. Keep going, the structure you've got is solid."

You will still tweak a word or two. The point is that you started from a calm, finished draft instead of a blinking cursor and a knot in your stomach. For the genuinely delicate ones, ask for two versions, one slightly warmer and one slightly firmer, and pick the one that fits.

4. Walk into every meeting already briefed

The difference between the person who runs the room and the person who gets caught flat-footed is almost always preparation, and almost nobody has time to prepare. You go from meeting to meeting with no gap to think. AI closes that gap by turning the scattered material you already have, the last email thread, the previous meeting notes, the agenda, into a one-page brief you can read in the elevator.

How to do it: Before a meeting, gather whatever context exists and ask for a brief built around what you actually need to know walking in. Outlook can pull recent related mail and documents to help you prep, and you can do the same by hand with any AI tool by pasting the relevant material.

Your prompt: "I have a thirty-minute meeting with a client, Hartley Group, in an hour. Below is our last email exchange and my notes from our previous call. Give me a one-page brief with four things. One, a two-line reminder of where we left off and what we promised. Two, the three topics most likely to come up. Three, two smart questions I should ask to move this forward. Four, anything sensitive I should handle carefully, based on the tone of these emails."

What comes back: A tight page that reminds you that you promised revised pricing by this week and have not sent it, flags that their last email was noticeably cooler than usual, suggests you lead by addressing the pricing directly rather than waiting to be asked, and gives you two questions that surface whether they are quietly shopping around.

That brief turns a meeting you would have improvised into one you steer. The sensitivity flag in particular catches the things you would have missed reading too fast.

5. Turn a transcript into decisions, owners, and follow-ups

The meeting ends and the real work begins, because somebody has to remember what was decided and who agreed to do what. Usually that somebody is you, reconstructing it from memory and half-finished notes, and the action items quietly evaporate. The fix is to stop relying on memory entirely. Capture the meeting, then let AI extract the structure.

How to do it: Get a transcript. Teams produces a full recap with summary, decisions, and action items after any recorded meeting. ChatGPT has a record mode that transcribes a meeting and turns it into structured notes. If you only have raw notes or a rough transcript, paste it in and ask for the specific shape you need, because a generic summary is useless and a clean action list is gold.

Your prompt: "Below is the transcript of our project meeting. Pull out three separate lists. One, decisions that were actually made, stated as final calls. Two, action items, and for each one name the owner and the deadline if it was mentioned. Three, open questions

that were raised but not resolved. If an action item has no clear owner, flag it as unassigned so I can chase it. Do not invent anything that is not in the transcript."

What comes back: "DECISIONS: Launch moves to July 15. Budget approved for the additional contractor. ACTION ITEMS: Dana to finalize the creative brief by July 1. Marcus to confirm contractor start date, no deadline given. UNASSIGNED: Someone needs to update the client on the new timeline, no owner named. OPEN QUESTIONS: Whether to run the email campaign before or after launch, tabled to next week."

The "flag unassigned" instruction is the quiet hero here. The action items that fall through the cracks are almost always the ones nobody explicitly owned. Now they are sitting at the top of your list with a flag on them.

6. The polite follow-up engine

Half of getting things done is chasing the things other people owe you, and most people are bad at it because chasing feels like nagging. So they wait, the thing slips further, and now the follow-up is even more awkward. AI removes the friction by drafting a follow-up that is warm, short, and gives the other person an easy way to respond, which is exactly the formula that gets a reply.

How to do it: Tell it who you are chasing, what you are waiting on, how long it has been, and the state of the relationship, because you chase a close colleague differently than a new client. Ask for a nudge, not a lecture.

Your prompt: "Write a short, friendly follow-up. I sent a proposal to a prospective client, Reza, eight days ago and have not heard back. We had a good first call so the tone is warm, not cold. I want to nudge without sounding desperate or pushy. Give them an easy out so it does not feel like pressure, something like a simple yes, no, or not yet works for me. Keep it under sixty words."

What comes back: "Hi Reza, just floating my proposal back to the top of your inbox in case it got buried, it happens to all of us. No rush at all. If you have any questions I'm happy to jump on a quick call, and if the timing isn't right, just let me know and I'll check back later in the quarter. Either way, good to know where things stand."

Once you see how well this works, build a small habit around it. Once a week, scan for the threads where you are waiting on someone, and let the tool draft the round of follow-ups

in one sitting. Five minutes of approving drafts replaces an hour of writing them one painful message at a time, and the things you are owed stop disappearing.

7. Triage the morning inbox into a plan

Opening a full inbox cold is how you lose the first hour of your day to the loudest email instead of the most important one. You react instead of prioritize. A faster start is to have AI sort the noise first, so you walk into a ranked plan instead of a wall of bold subject lines.

How to do it: If your inbox has built-in AI prioritization, lean on it, and Gmail's newer inbox features now surface what likely matters most. You can also do this deliberately by pasting in your unread subject lines and senders and asking for a triage, which works in any tool and forces you to think in priorities rather than chronology.

Your prompt: "Below is a list of my unread emails this morning, sender and subject line only. Sort them into three buckets. One, needs a real reply from me today, and tell me why. Two, quick acknowledgements I can clear in one line. Three, can wait or ignore. Within bucket one, rank them by what is most time-sensitive or relationship-critical."

What comes back: A clean plan that puts the client asking about a missed deadline at the top of bucket one with a note that it is relationship-critical, drops three newsletters and a calendar invite you already accepted into bucket three, and leaves you with a short, ranked list of what actually needs your brain. You handle the inbox in the order that protects your day.

This is less about AI writing for you and more about AI deciding the order so you do not have to. The hour you save is the one you would have spent context-switching between things that did not matter.

8. Build your reusable templates once

Almost everything you write in a week, you have written some version of before. The intro email. The project kickoff. The "circling back" nudge. The polite decline. You rebuild each one from scratch every time, which is the most wasteful habit in your whole inbox. The professional move is to build a small library of templates once, then let AI fill them in for each new situation in seconds.

How to do it: Spend twenty minutes one afternoon listing the eight or ten emails you write most often. For each, ask AI to turn one of your real past examples into a flexible template with clear blanks. Save them somewhere you can reach, a note, a doc, or saved instructions inside your AI tool. From then on, you do not write those emails. You hand the tool the template and the specifics, and it produces the finished version.

Your prompt to build one: "Here is a kickoff email I sent a new client last month, pasted below. Turn it into a reusable template. Keep my tone and structure, but replace the specifics with clear placeholders like [client name], [project], [first milestone], [date]. Add a one-line note at the top reminding me what to customize each time."

Your prompt to use one later: "Use my kickoff template below. The client is the Brennan Foundation, the project is their annual report redesign, first milestone is a concept review on July 9. Fill it in and tighten anything that reads awkwardly now that it is specific."

The first time you do this it feels like overhead. By the end of the first week you will have stopped writing your most common emails entirely, and that is the moment the inbox stops owning your mornings.

The one-page cheat sheet

Keep this beside you. These eight moves cover the whole loop, from the email that arrives to the meeting that generates ten more emails.

1. **Voice first.** Show it three emails you actually sent, once. Every draft after that sounds like you.
2. **Catch up, don't read.** Paste the brutal thread, ask the three questions that matter, demand it quote the lines that involve you.
3. **Hard emails.** Give it the off-the-record context and the outcome you want. Ask for a warmer and a firmer version.
4. **Brief before every meeting.** Hand it the prior emails and notes, ask for a one-page brief with the sensitive stuff flagged.
5. **Transcript to action.** Get a recap or transcript, extract decisions, owners, and deadlines, flag anything unassigned.
6. **Follow-up engine.** Nudge with warmth and an easy out. Run the whole week's chases in one sitting.

7. **Triage the morning.** Let it sort the inbox into reply-today, clear-in-one-line, and ignore, ranked.
8. **Templates once.** Turn your most-written emails into fill-in-the-blank templates and stop rewriting them forever.

None of this is exotic. It is the boring, repeatable plumbing of a workday, handed to a tool that is genuinely good at plumbing. The hours you get back are real, and they are yours.

This is a companion to [The Artificial Advantage: Mastering AI in the Modern Workplace](#) by Elvin M. Peters. The book gives you the full system for directing AI like the top 10%, across every part of your work. Get it at elvinpeters.com.

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